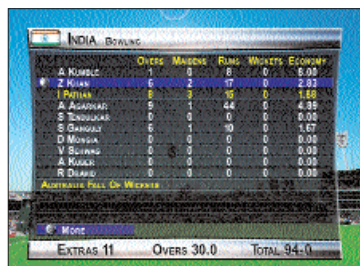




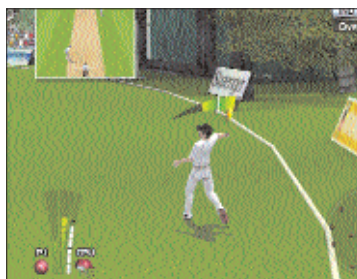
Match settings can be adjusted in relative detail



Scorecards are good and detailed—batting, bowling and summary



Like your shot? Take another look. At least five angles are available



Catch the throwing meter in the middle for a flat and fast throw



You can create custom teams of your choice and play against friends



Create a new player and decide what he's going to be good at

stump and Sehwag connects pushing it through the covers for one, getting India off the mark.

The ball is picked up in the deep and fired in straight to the 'keeper right over the stumps. To throw, there is a meter that has to be met right in the centre for a flat, fast and accurate one. By default, if you don't interfere, the throw will be a looping albeit accurate one.

We realised that judging a run takes some time since the default (and only) angle of viewing the match is not the usual 45-degree angle that shows you the field at large. Rather, the cameras are at a 30-degree angle, from where you can only see the umpire and 'keeper. And Sehwag ran three batsmen out. Oh well!

On the whole, batting is not tough, and once you get used to reading the three different meters, you can easily judge what to do. Another little marker in the middle of the pitch shows where the ball is going to pitch and the general direction it will move in. There are times, though, when this can totally bamboozle you. It can show 'good length' and suddenly be a half tracker. Watch out!

Look And Feel

The graphics look good, and the interface is rather well done. But although details on the ground are good, stadium layouts are not very realistic. An appeal for an LBW that is turned down is explained

in the replay using Hawk Eye. The same technology is also used to show a bowler's performance after every over. This is indeed realistic. Replays are also shown after every boundary, using about five different camera angles.

Characterisation

Bowlers are the most animated of the characters on the field, and also indulge in the occasional banter or sledging. Batting skills deteriorate as you go down the

Create A Player

BLIC 2005 also lets you create a custom player that you can add to any team. The player can be customised to be a batsman, bowler or all-rounder, and his skills with the bat can also be customised. You can then give him a face, choose his kit (good choice here) and define if he is stronger on the off or the on side.

Conclusion

Considering there are only two real options available for the cricket fanatic—EA Sports' Cricket 2005 and this—we would recommend you choose BLIC 2005 for the graphics and smoother gameplay. While most other features would match, this game is a tad better than the competition. None of them, however, are up to scratch, and we hope they get a lot better.

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Brian Lara International Cricket 2005

Publisher Codemasters Price Rs 1,299 Web site www.codemasters.com Minimum requirements Windows 98SE/ME/XP/2000, DirectX 9.0c, Pentium III or Athlon at 1GHz, 256 MB RAM, Supported Graphics card, DirectX 9 Compatible Sound Card, 8x CD-R Drive, 4.4 GB HDD Space Distributor Origin Marketing Pvt Ltd

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